

Stories of Online Harassment

Do you see when harassment happens?

What is online harassment?

Online harassment occurs on digital platforms like social media, email, forums or other spaces. It takes the form of deliberate and often repeated behaviours that intimidate, threaten or abuse an individual or group. Although it takes place online, these stories show how it has a deep impact on victims' offline lives.

1. A range of online harassment types

In this poster you can read excerpts from more than 100 real stories of online harassment. Each story is represented as a series of overlaid coloured texts.

The stories are grouped together according to the **TYPE OF HARASSMENT** described in them. Some stories are linked because they deal with more than one **TYPE OF HARASSMENT**. The stories in the middle of the diagram are those that mention three or more **TYPE OF HARASSMENT**.

Do you recognise these kinds of harassment from your own experiences? What do the stories have in common? How do they differ?

2. The people, places and motives behind harassment

If you look closely at the stories, you can see that each one is surrounded by three coloured ribbons. Each colour represents the 'who', 'where' and 'why' behind the harassment described in the story.

Who: The yellow ribbon represents the **type of relationship** between the harasser and the victim. Some harassers are 'strangers' to the victim, but many victims of online harassment know their harassers. You will read stories involving friends, partners, family members, coworkers and many others.

Where: Harassment can happen in all types of digital spaces, and often starts on one platform and spreads to many others. It can occur privately through DMs or more publicly in forums. The blue parts of the stories show **where it happens**. These include: Gaming, Dating, Social media, Forums, Chat rooms, Phone calls, and Text messages.

Why: Harassers are motivated by different circumstances and reasons. Parts in red show **why it happened**. Harassers' motives include ethnic, religious, relational (romantic), sexual, work-related, power-related, gender-related, retaliation, disability, economic and many others. Keep in mind that **there is never a justifiable reason for anyone to harass another person**, but harassers sometimes make justifications for their behaviours, or victims may speculate about why the harassment began.

3. Discover the details of harassment stories

As you'll see, each story contains three overlaid coloured texts that reveal who is involved, where it happened, and the motivations for why it happened. To read each layer and reveal the hidden details, you need coloured lenses.

Use your smartphone to access the coloured lens tool to decode the stories:

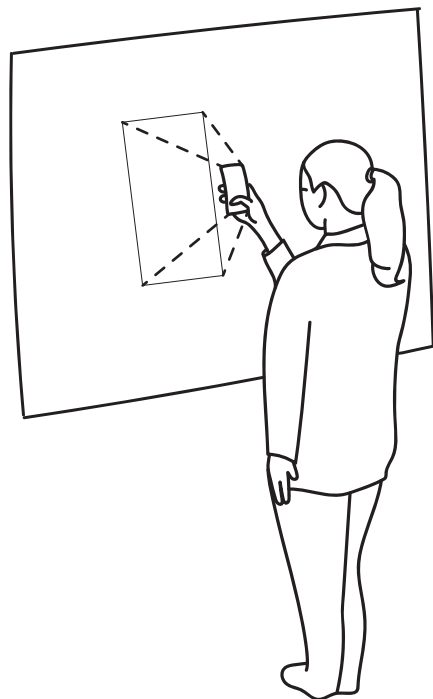
1 Scan the QR code or go to lens.theglassroom.org



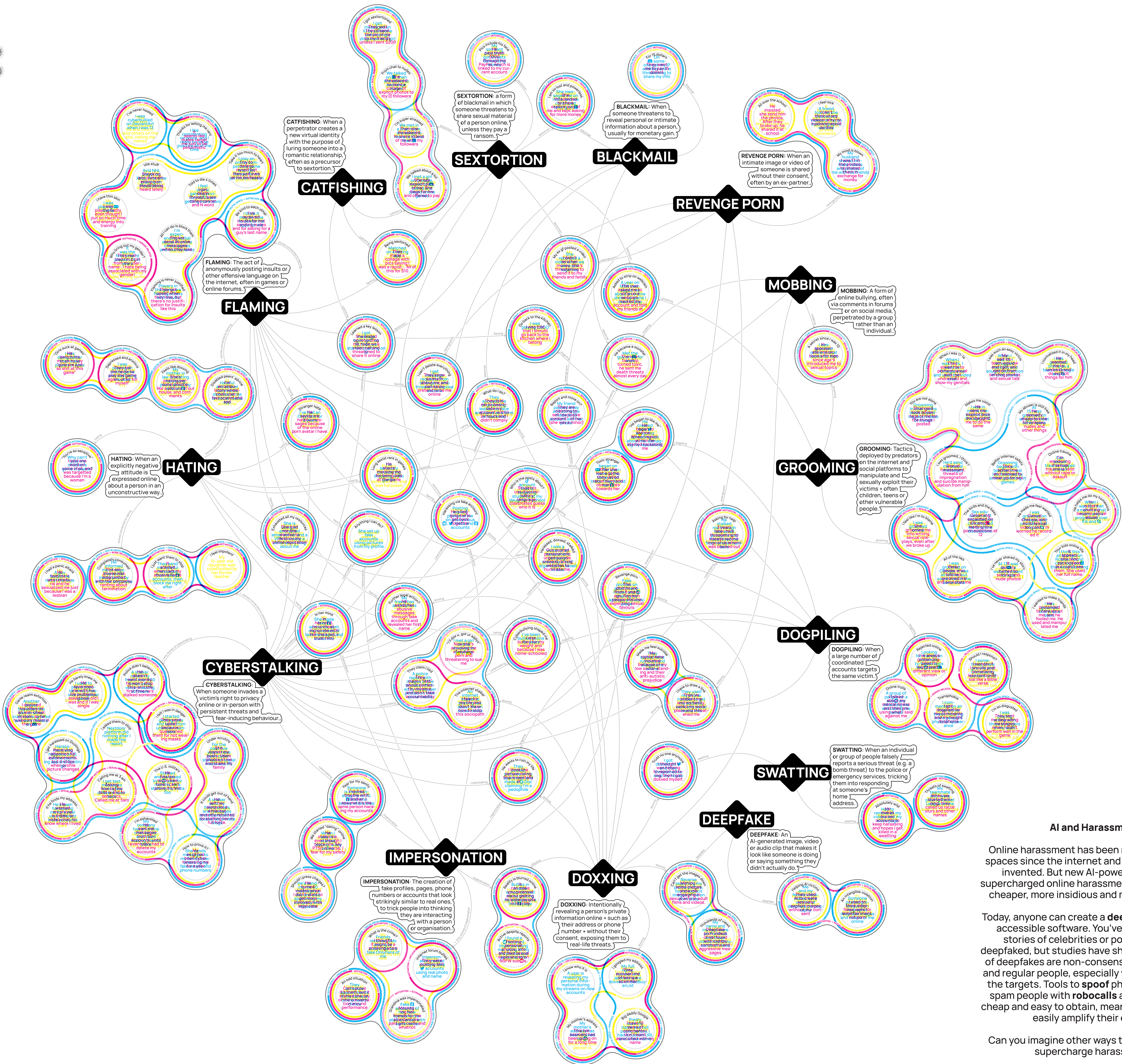
Press 'Start' and allow the website to use your smartphone photo camera. No information will be collected and the access will end after you close the website.



2 Position your phone on the calibration diagram, and click 'Calibrate'.



3 Using the coloured lens app, delve into the details of these stories. How are tech platforms exploited for purposes of harassment? How do online interactions influence offline life?



AI and Harassment

Online harassment has been rampant in digital spaces since the internet and social media were invented. But new AI-powered tools have supercharged online harassment, making it faster, cheaper, more insidious and more widespread.

Today, anyone can create a **deepfake** using easily accessible software. You've probably heard stories of celebrities or politicians being deepfaked, but studies have shown that over 90% of deepfakes are non-consensual, pornographic and regular people, especially women, are largely the targets. Tools to **spoof** phone numbers and spam people with **robocalls** and texts are also cheap and easy to obtain, meaning a harasser can easily amplify their efforts..

Can you imagine other ways that AI tools could supercharge harassment?